

ROHIT CHAWLA

MASTER OF MANY TRADES

You may have known **Varun Grover** as a lyricist, comic or screenwriter, but *Qala* recently showed us he can act, too. In addition, he has also taken to direction. There is nothing, it seems, he cannot do

Q. Did playing the part of a lyricist in *Qala* teach you something about your craft?
No, it didn't teach me anything about being a lyricist, but it did teach me that acting is a very difficult job. Actors get to be arrogant and vain because it takes a lot of work to be a good actor. Actors have to be in rhythm with co-actors, the camera, the essence of their lines. It is a bit like group meditation.

Q. While there's something deeply compelling about your lyrics for *Qala* and *Monica, O My Darling*, do you feel Hindi film music has maybe lost some of its earlier appeal?
Volumes have gone up and not all of it has the required longevity. A lot of these songs are made for instant response. You can't blame them when they're forgotten in six months. But I don't think Hindi film music has deteriorated. You can't discount the good.

Q. Your short film *Kiss*, about censorship, was screened at the Beijing Queer Film Festival recently. Would it have ruffled some feathers in China, do you think?
I was surprised when I heard my film was to be screened in China, but as happens, it is the members of a nation's LGBTQ community who always push the envelope. I think the purpose of art is to create avenues and reclaim liberal ground. We, like them, are trying, too.

Q. You're a lyricist, comedian, director, writer and so much more. Finally, what is your true calling?
I love cooking more than anything else. Even though it is something I do only for myself or my close friends, that, I think, is my true calling. But more seriously, I'd also say my true calling is being a writer and expressing my thoughts, either in comedy, lyrics, or screenwriting. I find joy in it all.

with Shreevatsa Nevatia